Colin King

San Francisco, CA · me@colinking.co · colinking.co · github.com/colinking · linkedin.com/in/colinking1

EXPERIENCE

Rippling *Staff Software Engineer* Feb 2024 – Apr 2026

- **Events Platform.** Tech lead for the Kafka-based event platform used by dozens of product teams, leading four engineers. Co-led a war room to harden it after payroll incidents, then turned the fixes into a reliability scorecard for every team.
- Built the pipeline behind the customer-facing Audit Log (Kafka, Flink, Iceberg), ingesting millions of events a day, and led it to GA with 50+ customers. Made the unmaintained Flink job behind it resilient to most schema changes.
- Cut the platform's consumer compute cost by more than half, interviewed six client teams to set its reliability roadmap, refactored the Go client and added its first tests, introduced AI code review (Claude, BugBot), and halved Flink CI time.
- Root-caused failures across team and vendor boundaries, e.g. traced a service OOM to Datadog's MongoDB tracing library and patched it upstream, and tracked a notifications incident to an HTTP/2 bug in the shared Go stack.
- **Data Bridge.** Embedded for two months on the internal data-sync platform (Go): shipped tracking for when data lands in each destination, async control events that decouple its services, and schema evolution.
- **Search.** Founding engineer and tech lead: took Search from spec to GA and grew the team from one engineer to six. Its OpenSearch architecture cut average query time from 3s to 100ms and grew coverage from 2 data types to over a dozen.
- Built change-data-capture ingestion on Kafka and a general-purpose permission system that enforces Rippling's access policies, and those of Google Drive, Confluence, and Slack, as OpenSearch query filters.
- Search became the retrieval layer for Rippling AI; owned its embedding ingestion and k-NN tuning on a 2 TB vector index. As the company's OpenSearch expert, added shard and storage monitoring to every cluster.

Airplane *Founding Engineer* Jan 2021 – Jan 2024

- First hire at a developer platform for internal tools (acquired by Airtable). Set technical direction across the stack and helped grow the team to 22: interviewed dozens of candidates, referred two senior engineers, and mentored six.
- Led product and engineering for Runbooks, a multi-step operations builder with an embedded V8 templating runtime: ran customer research, designed the UX, built the beta solo, and led two engineers to GA in six months.
- Proposed and led the pivot from no-code Runbooks to code-first Workflows. As tech lead, architected a durable execution runtime on Temporal that let developers write long-running, multi-step workflows as plain TypeScript.
- Built much of the core Tasks platform: a build system that deploys code without a Dockerfile, the Docker registry, parameter schemas, environments, local development, and the first Python SDK.
- Supported teams across the company: ran incident reviews and drove follow-ups to completion, resolved dozens of customer issues, and reviewed 1,700+ PRs and dozens of design docs.

Segment *Senior Software Engineer* Jul 2018 – Jan 2021

- Early engineer on an R&D effort to run Segment as a managed deployment into customer VPCs: shipped per-customer config replication, multi-pipeline support, alerting, custom domains, and prototyped Debugger support with ClickHouse.
- Tech lead for Protocols, Segment's data-quality product: shipped core full-stack features that unblocked several enterprise deals, mentored engineers, drove incident investigations, and stood in for the PM on-site with a major customer.
- Led the design of Segment's feature-flag service for tiered rollouts, from aligning a dozen stakeholders to shipping the worker, API, and UI. This became the de-facto way to roll out software at Segment.
- Stood up Segment's first ClickHouse deployment: wrote the design doc and built the ingestion worker and APIs behind Protocols violation counts, then scaled it with a staff engineer. Also used for incident investigations and pricing analysis.
- Primary author of Typewriter, an open-source generator of type-safe analytics clients (300k+ monthly npm downloads). Rewrote it around a pluggable generator interface and shared end-to-end tests; others then added Android and Swift.

Earlier Software engineering intern at Google (App Engine search) and Nextdoor (Kleiner Perkins Engineering Fellow).

EDUCATION

University of Maryland B.S. in Computer Science, minor in Statistics. GPA 3.98, *magna cum laude*. 2014 – 2017

Graduate coursework in Computer Science: completed all M.S. course credits. 2017 – 2018

Created and taught CMSC389L, a for-credit course on cloud computing with AWS, for two semesters.

SKILLS

Languages Go, Python, TypeScript

Systems Kafka, OpenSearch, Postgres, Redis, Kubernetes, AWS, Terraform, Datadog, React, Iceberg, Temporal, ClickHouse